Capítulo 4: ;18&ì watched the battle, which ended in just a few minutes, and could not help but marvel at the difference between a formal army and cannon fodder.

Motor: Gemini (gemini-3.1-flash-lite)

Levi watched the battle, which ended in just a few minutes, and could not help but marvel at the difference between a formal army and cannon fodder.

According to Old Charlie, Clay and his Knight Squad had participated in the battle against the Orcs' southward invasion four years ago and performed exceptionally well; it was during that campaign that Clay had made significant contributions, earning him the Life Source Liquid bestowed by Angelis, which allowed him to successfully promote to a formal Knight.

What Levi could not understand was where these motley thieves found the courage to dare to charge at a well-equipped Knight Squad.

"My Lord Baron, a total of 23 thieves were killed, 6 escaped, and the remaining 27 have been captured," Clay reported after arranging for the prisoners.

Perhaps because it was Levi who first discovered the thieves, Clay's attitude this time was fairly standard and respectful.

Levi immediately praised him: "Captain Clay, your Knight Squad truly lives up to its reputation as veterans who participated in the Great Orc War and made meritorious contributions; everyone here is an incredibly brave warrior. Once we reach our territory, I will reward you all."

"You are too kind, My Lord Baron; this is merely our duty," Clay replied, remaining neither servile nor overbearing.

Seeing this, Levi knew that these knights still held a distance from him, which would not do; he would have to rely on these knights for the next two years.

After thinking for a moment, he decided to just lay it all out: "Everyone, I know it is because of me that you are all so unlucky to have to go to such a dangerous place as Stormwind Territory. It is only natural that you have complaints, but I am powerless against this. The matter regarding the territory was not caused by me; someone is framing me, framing us. You only need to stay with me for two years. If we work together, perhaps you can safely make it through these two years. Think about it carefully!"

After Levi finished speaking, the surroundings fell silent. The knights exchanged glances, seemingly agreeing with Levi's words. Captain Clay, after taking a deep look at Levi, changed his previous attitude and said respectfully: "Thank you for your understanding, My Lord. Please rest assured, we will certainly uphold our duties."

"Then let us wish for a pleasant cooperation!" Levi said with relief.

Levi then began to discuss the group of thieves with Clay, while also voicing the doubts in his heart: "That is right, usually thieves run away as soon as they see us; how could they possibly dare to charge at us?"

Clay also suddenly realized this. He immediately found one of the captured minor leaders and began a harsh interrogation. These bandits were just a motley crew; after being threatened and intimidated by Clay, they immediately begged for mercy: "Please spare us, noble lord! We did not know you were a great noble lord. Our boss was instructed by someone to come and intercept and kill you. We did not know you were a noble, nor did we know there were formal knights here. Otherwise, even if you gave us ten times the courage, we would not have dared to attack you."

Now, Clay and the surrounding knights believed what Levi had said earlier; the territory swap was indeed someone playing tricks, not caused by Levi acting on impulse as they had previously thought. They had truly misunderstood the Baron.

"It seems this was orchestrated by the person who swapped my territory," Levi speculated.

"But why would they send this motley crew?" Clay asked, still somewhat puzzled.

"Because of Angelis, I can only die in Stormwind Territory, and absolutely not within the kingdom. These thieves were likely meant to wear down your Knight Squad. If we had not discovered them in advance and had truly walked into their ambush, I think your Knight Squad would certainly have suffered casualties. In that case, after I arrived at Stormwind Territory, I would die even faster."

Captain Clay thought about it and realized it was indeed true; if they had not discovered them in advance, that First-Order Warrior alone could have caused them some casualties.

Upon hearing Captain Clay's confirmation, the surrounding knights began to murmur amongst themselves.

Afterwards, the looks they gave Levi changed. From this point on, the barrier between this Knight Squad and Levi was effectively removed; after all, they were now all in the same boat, and none of them could escape.

Clay then suggested sending a knight back to Tulip City to report this to Angelis, but was stopped by Levi: "Heh, they only forbid me from dying within the kingdom; that does not include you all. Do you think the person you send will be able to reach Tulip Territory?"

Clay was stunned, then gritted his teeth and said: "Damn despicable wretches."

"Let us go! We have no retreat now; we can only head to Stormwind Territory." After saying this, he signaled everyone to set off. As for this batch of thief prisoners, Levi planned to sell them to Viscount Leon ahead, which would count as some income; it would be perfect for buying some things at Gray Fortress.

Five days later, Levi and his party finally arrived at Gray Fortress.

Gray Fortress is situated within the Gray Mountain Range, a location with dangerous and strategic terrain. The Orcs never allowed the Alpha Kingdom to build a fortress here, and almost every time they moved south, they would focus their attacks on this place, making it impossible for a fortress to be established. It was not until 250 years ago, when a giant gold mine was discovered within the current Lyon Viscount Territory, that the royal family became determined to build a fortress in the Gray Mountain Range, ultimately deploying three legions to guard the Gray Mountain Range and finally successfully constructing Gray Fortress.

However, 100 years ago, after the gold mine was exhausted, and coupled with the fact that the Alpha Kingdom became increasingly adept at warfare, the Orcs shifted their main offensive focus to other kingdoms, only conducting raids and plundering the borderlands of the Alpha Kingdom. Consequently, the royal family withdrew two legions, leaving only the Northeast Legion responsible for the defense of the Frostmoon Province, and they would only send additional legions when the Northeast Legion requested reinforcements.

The Northeast Legion usually remains stationed at the rear in Frost Moon City, only sending one battalion to guard Gray Fortress, and only increasing troops here depending on the situation when the Orcs move south. The military organization of the Alpha Kingdom consists of squads, companies, battalions, legions, and army groups, with non-fixed numbers of personnel. At this time, it was the Eighth Battalion of the Northeast Legion that was guarding Gray Fortress.

The Battalion Commander, Klein, is a Fifth-Order Silver Knight, and he has two deputy commanders under him: one is a Fifth-Order Silver Warrior, and the other is a Fourth-Order Great Warrior, along with a First Cavalry Company Commander who is also a Fourth-Order Great Warrior. After arriving at Gray Fortress, Levi first needed to collect the supplies and population for his new lordship. This is a special consideration from the royal family for every new lord of a border barony, so that those soldiers who had fought bravely to earn military merit would not find themselves unable to develop after being enfeoffed with a border territory, thereby generating complaints and greatly reducing the value of military merit.